the Drokung Sambha Bridge next to Khenzemane and another company, minus a platoon, was at Serkhim just below Hathung-la. Lieutenant Colonel K. S. Harihar Singh, with Major Oscar Thomas as his adjutant, was commanding the battalion. The Battalion HQ and one company was deployed on the southern bank of the Nam Ka Chu while Major Balbir Singh's company was across the river, below the sharp cliffs of the Thagla which seemed to rise vertically just beyond his position. By the time the river had tumbled down from the icy heights to Bridge 1, the lowest point in the Nam Ka Chu Valley, it had lost considerable altitude.

The Grenadiers were huddled amongst the boulders nearly on the riverbed, all bunched up together. There was a single stone hut in the area, which was occupied by the CO and the six officers. The men had constructed sangars for themselves amongst the boulders, which were the only protection they had from the elements. The Intelligence officer, Second Lieutenant R. S. Kahlon, felt that it was hopeless as a defensive position; limited and cramped, no two positions within the battalion were more than 180 metres apart. Like the Rajputs, the Grenadiers had virtually no support weapons. The men had carried 3-inch mortars all the way from the plains but these were useless as there were no bombs. A single telephone line had been laid out by the Signals detachment that ran from Brigade HQ through 9 Punjab's location at Bridge 2 to Bridge 1 and then onto the Division Tac HQ. Both the 9 Punjab and 4 Grenadier communication networks were hooked onto the same line.

'The fear of the unknown', wrote my father in *Rivers of Silence* (he had been with the men until a couple of months before), 'plays a great part in conditioning the behaviour of men, even if as soldiers they are meant to be able to face uneven odds at times. Those who had earlier combat experience were perhaps even more tense, with images of past encounters in their minds, knowing that they must put up a brave front. Patriotic ideals recede into the background, what now counts is the next man and JCOs and officers. They're in it together and while fear has a numbing effect, a conscious effort has to be made to conceal it.'

KNIFED IN THE BACK

The Chinese had started infiltrating across the Nam Ka Chu on the night of 18 October itself. Small parties had identified the crossing points between and upstream of the Rajput positions, which had large gaps between them.